

Eurasian curlew

Sensitive probe

Length 24 in (60 cm)

Range Europe, Asia, and Africa

Habitat Soft shores

The extremely long, slender bill of the curlew is the perfect tool for probing soft, wet sand and mud for buried animals such as worms and clams. It can reach deeper than any other shorebird. Its bill tip is touch-sensitive, allowing it to detect invisible prey. Curlews often use their long legs to wade in shallow water, but they also pick small crabs and similar animals off the exposed shore.



Ruff

Dazzling display

Length 12 in (30 cm)

Range Europe, Asia, Africa, and Australia

Habitat Muddy estuaries

Like many shorebirds, ruffs breed on inland sites such as marshes and grasslands. But, unusually, rival males perform competitive displays to attract females, showing off their flamboyant breeding plumage. At the end of

the breeding season, their long feathers fall out, to be replaced with much more modest gray and brown plumage for the winter. Ruffs feed in the salty creeks of river estuaries, as well as further inland.



Black-winged stilt

High rise

Length 16 in (40 cm)

Range Worldwide except cold regions

Habitat Shallow coastal water

Many shorebirds have long legs for wading in the water in search of prey. The legs of the black-winged stilt are so long that it can feed in much deeper water than other birds, but they make feeding on land very awkward.



Roseate spoonbill

Specialist

Length 32 in (81 cm)

Range North America, Central America, and South America

Habitat Coastal lagoons

Some birds have highly specialized bills for feeding in a certain way. They include spoonbills, which hold their spoon-shaped bills slightly open and sweep them from side to side just below the surface of the water. The roseate spoonbill uses this technique to catch shrimp as well as other small animals. Spoonbills often feed in small groups, wading in lines through the shallows.

Oystercatcher

Smasher and prober

Length 18 in (46 cm)

Range Europe, Asia, and Africa

Habitat Rocky and sandy shores

A few shorebirds use their bills to smash or pry open shellfish, including mussels and clams. The bright red bill of the oystercatcher is specially reinforced for hammering into their shells, and has a bladelike tip for cutting through the tough shell-closing muscles. Oystercatchers that live on rocky shores have the strongest bills; others that live on softer shores have more finely pointed bills, which they use for probing the sand, like curlews.

